Attachment 4

Principal Investigator's Assessment of the Ethical Nature of the Research

To Renounce Liberty? A Public-Goods Experiment on (Un)Democratic Reversal

Janne Tukiainen | janne.tukiainen@utu.fi | Version 2.6 – proposed amendment | 20 October 2026

Assessment

The study targets 300 adults who complete one paid, approximately 60-minute laboratory session. Participants make ~~anonymous~~ private, incentivised decisions in a fictional public-service setting. The study does not use deception about the rules or payment calculation, collect biological samples, intervene in physical integrity, expose participants to unusually strong stimuli, or target children or other groups whose capacity to consent is impaired.

Foreseeable burdens are limited to waiting in a synchronized task and possible mild discomfort with a crisis scenario or unequal point allocations. Registration through ~~the host laboratory's participant system~~ UTU Choice Lab's UTU RPP/TOKA participant system provides its general rules and privacy information. Before the experimental task, participants receive project-specific plain-language information and give a short electronic confirmation that they voluntarily agree to this study. The information states that the detailed research question will be explained after paid decisions. This limited incomplete disclosure avoids cueing the institutional choice under study; it withholds no information about task rules, payment, data processing, foreseeable risks, or voluntary participation. Participants receive an immediate debrief after the task. They may decline or stop without giving a reason or suffering negative consequences. The ~~laboratory manager~~ researcher or trained research assistant finalises a consenting roster divisible by five before paid play, monitors the session, and manages interruptions without generating decisions on a participant's behalf. A countdown prompts participants to choose and confirm; reaching zero does not submit a response or remove the right to decide.

The task is scientifically necessary because the research question concerns consequential choices, repeated interaction, and whether the same participant changes an institutional decision after conditions change. The design minimises burden through one visit, unpaid practice, comprehension checks, neutral wording, and payment of EUR 10 plus a performance bonus of up to EUR 5. The first ten-person session offers six optional feedback questions after the main task. The separate form cannot be linked to experimental records, and answering or declining has no effect on payment.

Privacy and data protection

The production oTree study and coded research data are hosted on University of Turku IT servers in Finland. ~~The host laboratory retains the identifying information needed for recruitment and payment and gives the research team only coded data. The research team never receives any temporary identity-to-code link; the host laboratory removes it after compensation under its procedure.~~ UTU RPP/TOKA retains recruitment and attendance information separately from the experimental data; it neither assigns oTree participant codes nor receives payment or research-response data. The research team administers immediate payment using a separate code-and-amount list and retains any named payment receipt without an oTree code. Access to coded research data is restricted to Janne Tukiainen, Hector Bahamonde, and authorised personnel. Results are reported without identifying participants. After payment reconciliation, the code-and-amount list is destroyed. Anonymisation also requires removing or coarsening identifying combinations and a documented disclosure-risk review. Until anonymisation is confirmed, coded data remain restricted personal data as specified in the privacy notice and data management plan.

The final questionnaire directly asks about past party vote, left–right placement, and attitudes toward democracy and political authority; these answers are handled as special-category personal data. Data minimisation, optional responses, separation of identities, restricted access, secure University storage, disclosure review, and aggregate reporting reduce the residual risk. The accompanying project-specific DPIA documents the assessment and will be reviewed if the platform or collected variables change materially.

Conclusion

In my assessment, the protocol's scientific value is proportionate to its limited foreseeable risks and burdens.

The participant information, consent procedure, compensation, laboratory safeguards, and data-protection measures support voluntary and informed participation. Data collection will begin only after the required ethical and institutional approvals are in place.

Principal Investigator: Janne Tukiainen, Professor, Turku School of Economics, University of Turku
Contact: janne.tukiainen@utu.fi; +358 50 308 3620

Date and signature: _____